

1HT-500f: Growing Up in a Media  
World Content analysis data chart

|                                           |                                   | Commercial<br>network<br>% (number) | Public<br>broadcasting<br>% (number) | Online<br>% (number) | Total<br>% (number) |  |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------|--|
| Gender                                    | Male                              | 66.7% 8                             | 41.7% 5                              | 75% 9                | 61.1%               |  |
|                                           | Female                            | 33.3% 4                             | 41.7% 5                              | 25% 3                | 33.3%               |  |
|                                           | Transgender                       |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |
|                                           | Other                             |                                     | 16.6% 2                              |                      | 5.6%                |  |
| Age                                       | 0-11                              |                                     | 75% 9                                | 50% 6                | 41.7%               |  |
|                                           | 12-17                             | 25% 3                               |                                      |                      | 8.3%                |  |
|                                           | 18-34                             | 25% 3                               | 8.3% 1                               | 25% 3                | 19.4%               |  |
|                                           | 35-49                             | 25% 3                               | 16.7% 2                              | 16.7% 2              | 19.4%               |  |
|                                           | 50-65                             |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |
|                                           | over 65                           | 25% 3                               |                                      | 8.3% 1               | 11.1%               |  |
| Ethnicity                                 | Asian/Asian-American              |                                     | 8.3% 1                               | 33.3% 4              | 13.8%               |  |
|                                           | Black                             | 8.3% 1                              | 33.3% 4                              | 8.3% 1               | 16.7%               |  |
|                                           | Latino/a                          |                                     | 8.3% 1                               |                      | 2.8%                |  |
|                                           | Native American                   | 16.7% 2                             |                                      | 8.3% 1               | 8.3%                |  |
|                                           | White                             | 41.7% 5                             |                                      | 25% 3                | 22.2%               |  |
|                                           | Multiracial/<br>Multiethnic       |                                     | 16.7% 2                              |                      | 5.6%                |  |
|                                           | Other                             | 33.3% 4                             | 33.3% 4                              | 25% 3                | 30.6%               |  |
| Occupation<br>or major<br>activity        | (You create the<br>categories)    |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |
|                                           | Kids                              | 25% 3                               | 58.3% 7                              | 33.3% 4              | 38.9% 14            |  |
|                                           | Parents                           | 8.3% 1                              | 8.3% 1                               |                      | 5.6% 2              |  |
|                                           | Family member                     |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |
|                                           | Animals                           |                                     | 16.7% 2                              | 25% 3                | 13.9% 5             |  |
|                                           | Adults                            | 66.7% 8                             | 16.7% 2                              | 41.7% 5              | 41.7% 15            |  |
| Your<br>attribute                         | (Relevant categories)<br>(number) |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |
|                                           |                                   |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |
| Conflict<br>Behavior                      | Disagreement                      | 8                                   | 9                                    | 7                    |                     |  |
|                                           | Physical Fight                    | 14                                  | 1                                    | 15                   |                     |  |
| Technology/<br>media usage<br>in the show |                                   | 12                                  | 5                                    | 7                    |                     |  |
|                                           |                                   |                                     |                                      |                      |                     |  |

## Report

Across nine children's programs from commercial networks, public broadcasting, and streaming platforms, I examined them together to understand the messages children might take away about conflict. Although the shows varied widely in genre and target age, I focused on the most frequently appearing characters and coded how conflict was portrayed. I also tracked appearances of technology, though not as part of the conflict category.

The attribute I studied most closely was conflict behavior, which I defined as either "disagreement" (arguments, complaints, or opposing views) or "physical fight" (intentional acts of physical aggression, including using tools or powers). I chose this because conflict offers clear insight into how media might shape children's understanding of relationships and problem-solving.

Across the nine shows, I counted 24 disagreements and 30 physical fights. Conflict appeared in every show but differed by genre. Preschool educational programs featured light, social-emotional disagreements that typically ended with cooperative resolutions. These moments modeled communication skills appropriate for young children. In contrast, action-oriented animated shows relied heavily on physical fights to drive their plots. Even if children can distinguish fantasy violence from real life, the frequency of battles suggests that many young viewers regularly see conflict framed as physical confrontation.

Although technology wasn't part of my main attribute, it appeared 24 times, often woven naturally into the stories. In preschool shows, technology supported exploration or problem-solving. In action shows, it functioned more dramatically—as gadgets, weapons, or power sources. Its consistent presence suggests that technology is highly normalized across children's media, regardless of the show's educational goals.

Coding additional character attributes highlighted patterns in representation. Male characters appeared more frequently than female characters, especially in action shows. Preschool programs tended to show more intentional racial and cultural diversity, while stylized or anthropomorphic

characters in action shows made ethnicity harder to determine, leading me to code several as “Other.” This reflected how representation often varies by genre and production priorities.

Some coding decisions required interpretation. Certain moments sat between playful banter and genuine disagreement, and it was not always clear whether a device counted as technology or a magical object. Estimating character age, especially in stylized animation, was also inconsistent. These challenges reminded me that content analysis, while systematic, still involves subjective judgment.

Overall, the shows strongly reflected their genre expectations: educational programs emphasized cooperation and emotional learning, while action shows centered battles, missions, and heroic conflicts. Children who primarily watch one type may develop different assumptions about how people resolve problems. Despite the small sample, this project made me wonder how media influences children’s real-life understanding of disagreement and how the portrayal of technology shapes their expectations of the tools around them.

## Appendix

Online programming for children:

1. The Boss Baby: Back in Business E1 (Netflix)
2. Tom and Jerry Tales Season 2 E1: More Powers to you (Netflix)
3. Lego: Ninja E1 (Netflix)

Public broadcasting children's programming:

1. Sesame Street: Cookie Monster's Big Puzzle (PBS)
2. Lyla in the Loop, Blast Off/Sister Secrets
3. Molly of Denali: Caught Off Gourd/Dogsled Special Delivery

Commercial network (ABC Kids)

1. Batwheels
2. X-Men: The animated series
3. Spider-Man: The animated series